

IN CONTEXT

The Dissolution of the Monasteries

By the Act of Supremacy (1534), Henry VIII became head of the Church of England, gaining complete authority over it. Two years later, his chief minister, Thomas Cromwell, began the process of suppressing religious houses—monasteries, convents, and priories—seizing all their assets for the Crown. Waltham Abbey was the last to be suppressed, in March 1540. This policy had serious consequences for English musicians—many lost both their home and their livelihood. Countless musical manuscripts were also lost when the monastic libraries were sold off or even destroyed.



WALTHAM ABBEY, ESSEX, ENGLAND